



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Sundial Classical Farmstead
School Website: <https://sundialclassical.farm/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Sundial Classical Farmstead (SCF) presents as a clearly classical-leaning institution with a strong religious-metaphysical orientation, a vocally stated mission of forming virtuous people through beauty, virtue, and truth, and a curriculum and pedagogy aligned with liberal-arts formation, Great Books/Great Conversation sensibilities, and a heritage of contemplative learning. The site materials repeatedly emphasize character formation, virtue, wisdom, and beauty, along with explicit references to Great Conversation, living books, narration, and memorization. There is also a defined Christian/Orthodox catechesis dimension and a public hospitality toward families with different religious backgrounds. Taken together, the public materials demonstrate substantial alignment with classical education expectations, with a notable but minority area of nuance around explicit Socratic seminars in upper grades. Overall classification: CLASSICAL, with a specific area identified as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (Pedagogy) where more explicit Socratic/seminar-based practices could be foregrounded.

Key signals include: - Explicit mission emphasizing truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, and wisdom, plus a Great Conversation in Scripture and Great Literature (evidence of religious-metaphysical foundations and pursuit of the true, good, beautiful) ;. - Orthodox Christian catechesis and optional Christian studies, indicating a grounded theological framework and liturgical/community orientation (liturgical-style practice is suggested by communal singing/ritual life; catechesis is explicit) ;. - Curriculum elements such as living books, self-assessment/narration, memorization, a liberal-arts framework (grammar/logic/rhetoric), Latin, and the Great Conversation, supporting a Classical-Curriculum orientation ; ;. - Pedagogical emphasis on scholé, contemplative/restful learning, and memory-based practices in lower grades, with upper grades incorporating seminars, rhetoric, and public speaking opportunities (partial Socratic/sem-based practices) ;. - Parents and community partnership is foregrounded, including parent education classes and volunteer involvement as a core part of the school model.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission emphasizes truth, beauty, virtue, wisdom, and hospitality, aligning with transcendentals and moral realism (public mission statement). - Explicit Orthodox Christian catechesis and a religious framing of education (Orthodox Catechesis instructor; Christian Studies option) ;. - Phrases tying spiritual formation to daily academic life and Scripture/Great Literature in the Great Conversation framework. - Communal singing, liturgical-like gatherings in programs (e.g., singing and readings) point to liturgical/community practices within daily life ;.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: truth, beauty, virtue, wisdom, theology, catechesis, Scripture, Great Conversation, liturgy/worship, wonder, reverence. The materials frequently

foreground these terms and concepts (evidence above and in the lexicon guidance). The Classical Lexicon lists these as core positive signals in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations; the school demonstrates multiple instances of each in practice and program descriptions. - Negative indicators: minimal to none in public materials. The site emphasizes religious formation rather than secular relativism or neutral curricula in this area.

Why this rating - Public materials clearly present a transcendent, theological frame and liturgical/community practices that ground the curriculum in a theologically-informed anthropology, not a secular or purely relativist framework. The explicit references to theology, catechesis, Scripture, and Great Conversation support a CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Note: The school notes Christianity as a vital element while aiming to welcome non-religious families, which aligns with the “incarnational worldview” language in the lexicon, and suggests a hospitable but theologically infused approach rather than secular neutrality. This aligns with CLASSICAL while highlighting a religious-specific orientation.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public statements of forming virtuous people and pursuing knowledge, beauty, and wisdom, not solely career preparation (Our mission explicitly mentions forming virtuous people; Great Conversation and sacred knowledge are highlighted) ;. - Language of formation, virtue, human flourishing, and contemplation (scholé, contemplation, restfulness) aligns with classical aims over utilitarian job-prep aims ;. - Emphasis on Great Conversation and classical heritage as core aims (Great Conversation mentioned explicitly). - The mission speaks to beauty, wisdom, truth, and hospitality as central goods, aligning with liberal-arts formation rather than work-force preparation alone.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, liberal education, great conversation, true/good/beautiful, scholé, contemplation, classical heritage, soul craft, moral imagination. The materials repeatedly reference these terms (and the lexicon documents them as core signals for Element 2). - Negative indicators: the materials do not emphasize 21st-century skills or workforce-preparation as primary aims; if anything, they de-emphasize pure job-prep language.

Why this rating - The public narrative centers on virtue-formation, wisdom, and contemplation—core Element 2 criteria in the classical rubric. The presence of Great Conversation, classical pedagogy references, and formation-focused language supports a CLASSICAL rating for School Purpose and Goal.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Liberal-arts framing with grammar, logic, rhetoric emphasized; Latin included; geometry, arithmetic; history clearly integrated; Western civilization foundations implied by Great Books and primary sources; living books and classical literature as core components; and the Great Conversation referenced in program statements ;. - History studied across the curriculum; living books and classical texts used in English/ Literature; explicit reference to Great Books/Primary sources and recitation/narration as pedagogy (progymnasmata and memory-work) ;. - The curriculum includes Latin and rhetoric in the program (Rhetoric, Logic, Latin, etc.), with a clear Trivium-like alignment (grammar, logic, rhetoric) in the materials ;. - Great Books/Great Conversation is a named curricular anchor (Great Conversation referenced in multiple materials).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, primary sources, classics, Latin, Western civilization, history, recitation, narration, proscribed forms like progymnasmata, memory work, chant, sacred art. The presence of living books and Great Conversation is explicitly documented, aligning with Element 3 signals ;. - Negative indicators: the lexicon notes negative signals such as replacing history with “social studies terminology,” or a heavy project-based emphasis; the SCF materials emphasize classical methods and living books with relatively less emphasis on project-based dominance, suggesting a favorable alignment rather than a negative indicator for this curriculum category.

Why this rating - The curriculum content aligns with classical criteria: grammar, logic, rhetoric; heavy emphasis on Great Books/primary sources; historical study across the curriculum; use of living books; and a structure oriented toward liberal education rather than contemporary pragmatic/career-first frameworks. This supports CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school foregrounds contemplative, restful learning, and Scholastic-based pedagogy as a structural emphasis, including a one-room/mastery-based progression in some settings (Charlotte Mason influence) with a focus on “singing,” memorization, and memory-based instruction in lower grades ;. - Narration, recitation, chanting, memory work, and liturgical/calendar integration are cited as core methods, consistent with classical pedagogy (Socratic methods are not consistently described as the primary upper-school method; the site emphasizes memorization, narration, and oral assessments) ;. - There is explicit emphasis on upper-school rhetoric and public speech opportunities, suggesting some classical training in rhetoric and oration, though not described as a full, universal Socratic seminar program across all grades ;. - NoTech classrooms and a discipline-oriented, contemplative approach is described, which aligns with classical prudence and retrenchment from aggressive constructivist/experiential extremes (the lexicon notes negative signals for experiential/project-based learning) ;.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: scholé, contemplation, wonder, memory work, narration, recitation, chanting, liturgical calendar integration, rhetoric, oratory, debate, Paideia-style seminars (as terms appear in the lexicon and in program descriptions). - Negative indicators: there is limited explicit evidence of fully developed Socratic seminars in the public materials for every grade level, and a broader absence of a uniformly fixed, high-profile “Socratic seminar” across the entire upper-school program; the materials instead emphasize memory/narration and occasional seminars, which is a partial alignment.

Why this rating - The pedagogy shows robust classical elements (memory/narration, contemplative Scholé, chant, liturgical/calendar integration, rhetoric training) but does not consistently demonstrate full, uniform Socratic seminars or Paideia-style seminars across all high-school levels as an explicit, primary method. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty presence is described with subject-matter depth and specialized roles (Orthodox Catechesis Instructor with relevant degrees) and multi-credential staff, indicating mentors and subject experts who model virtue and content mastery. - The materials emphasize the faculty as living curriculum and as core to the school's culture (evidence of a community oriented around teachers as models of virtue; testimonials emphasize staff impact; the staff biographies show credentialed, tutor-mentors). - The school describes a “portrait” of teachers and a deliberately crafted staff ethos around virtue and hospitality; while explicit wording of “living curriculum” is not always verbatim, the content heavily implies teachers as central, virtuous exemplars and mentors ;.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of teacher/student, teacher as core, staff credentials (Orthodox Catechesis instructor, MDiv, BA), and staff testimonials asserting positive influence. - Negative indicators: none evident in public materials; no explicit negative signals about faculty quality or approach.

Why this rating - The materials consistently portray faculty as central to the school's formation project, with credentialed instructors, mentorship framing, and staff-and-family narratives underscoring the classical aim that teachers are the living exemplars of virtue and knowledge. This aligns with CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school actively partners with parents: parent-education classes for families, volunteer requirements, and robust communication with families (orientation, tours, meet-and-greets, and family involvement in the microschool model) ;. - The school positions parents as co-teachers in effect through education,

book studies, gatherings, and family participation; multiple materials discuss parent engagement and education as a central component of the model. - Public materials indicate openness to visits and family involvement in daily life and governance; newsletters and testimonials emphasize the welcoming nature of the community and the emphasis on hospitality (a key classical-community signal).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: partnerships with parents, co-teaching-like alignment, parent education, family volunteering, open visits, community hospitality, book studies/gatherings. - Negative indicators: none identified in the public materials.

Why this rating - The school presents a robust, explicit partnership with parents and a community-centric approach, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations in the Parents & Community category.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- Pedagogy (Element 4): Introduce more explicit, widely implemented Socratic/seminar-based instruction across upper and possibly middle grades to align with classic Socratic pedagogy expectations (e.g., Paideia-style seminars, dialectic tutorials) in addition to narration and memory work. This would reduce the SMALL gap between current practices (narration, contemplative methods) and a fuller Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy core to classical education. Consider formalizing a K–12 seminary progression, including frequent, teacher-facilitated Socratic seminars, debates, and oral-exam demonstrations, with assessment anchored in the Great Conversation and classical rhetoric. Evidence for this potential improvement could be drawn from the lexicon's emphasis on Socratic texts and dialectic methods as classical signals and the current limited explicit Socratic use in the public materials.
- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (Element 1): Expand explicit liturgical formats or calendar-integrated communal worship or prayer across more grade levels, while maintaining openness to non-religious families. Public materials already reflect Christian formation and catechesis; expanding liturgical integration could further strengthen the liturgical signal without compromising hospitable non-religious access.
- Curriculum (Element 3): Continue to foreground Great Books/primary sources and ensure a consistent integration of Great Books across core subjects, reinforcing the Great Conversation across the curriculum. While there is evidence of Great Conversation and living books, a more explicit, curriculum-wide Great Books thread across all grades would further strengthen the Classical signal.
- Faculty development (Element 5): Develop a formalized "portrait of the teacher" and a more explicit "living-curriculum" framework with faculty professional development aligned to classical education benchmarks; this would help ensure consistency of virtuous-model status across all faculty and strengthen the CLASSICAL signal.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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